

The Idea That Never Made It Out of the Rock Pile

by Mario D. Atkins

There is a moment in fraud prevention that nobody talks about.

It is not the moment the fraud happens. It is not the moment the member sits across from you, hands shaking, realizing their Social Security deposit is gone. It is not the moment you spend the next two hours locking down their account, changing their username, closing the compromised profile, opening a new one, switching direct deposits, filing the affidavit, notarizing it yourself because you are also a commissioned notary and the member does not have time to go anywhere else.

The moment nobody talks about is the one that comes after all of that.

When the member leaves. When the branch quiets. When you sit with what just happened and you think: this did not have to occur. And you think: I know exactly where the gap is. And then you think the most dangerous thought of all.

I know how to fix it.

I spent fifteen years inside a financial institution. I started at the front line, helping members with the full range of what a credit union offers. Loans. Deposits. Service recovery. The daily texture of people's financial lives. Over time I moved into leadership. I became an assistant branch manager. I managed people, audits, cash operations, fraud escalations, and the space between what the institution needed and what the member standing in front of me needed, which were not always the same thing.

And I became, without anyone asking me to, something of an informal expert in fraud.

Not because I sought the title. Because the fraud kept coming, and I was there, and I stayed.

I learned early that fraudsters do not attack the institution. They attack the people. They attack the convenience the institution built for those people. Online banking. Remote access. Self-service transfers. All of it designed to reduce friction for the legitimate customer. All of it, simultaneously, a door left open for the person who is not the legitimate customer but has learned to perform as one.

I learned that debit card fraud and wire transfer fraud are not the same legal or regulatory animal. The recoupment paths are different. The liability standards are different. I learned what the regulation protected and what it did not. I learned that when a member hands over their access device, even under duress, even under manipulation, the institution's obligation shifts in ways most members never understand until the moment they need to understand it most.

I watched people lose money they could not afford to lose. I watched institutions do what they were legally permitted to

do, which was not always what the member believed they were obligated to do.

And through all of it, I kept coming back to one place in the process where the exposure was largest and the protection was thinnest.

Wire transfers.

Here is what the authorization process for a wire transfer looked like from where I stood.

A member submits a request online. They fill out the form. Beneficiary information. Routing number. Account number. They upload identification. They click submit. The request moves to a queue. A specialist receives it, reviews it, runs the required compliance checks, and if everything passes, executes the wire.

There is a dollar threshold built into that process. A limit designed to create friction for large transactions. To slow things down enough that someone can review them.

That limit is not identity verification. It is a speed bump.

Because here is what that process cannot tell you. It cannot tell you whether the person who logged in, navigated to the wire transfer form, filled it out correctly, uploaded an identification document, and clicked submit is actually the person whose name is on the account.

It can tell you that someone knew the username. Someone knew the password. Someone completed the multifactor authentication. It cannot tell you that the person is who they say they are.

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And I knew, from the fraud cases I worked, that this gap was not theoretical. People were losing money through wire transfers they did not authorize. The institution was reviewing what existed in the process and finding, in many cases, that the process had been followed correctly. That the fraud had been executed through legitimate channels. That the liability was difficult to place.

Members were being told, in various forms, that the money was gone and the options were limited.

I sat with that for a long time.

The solution I kept arriving at was not new technology. It was existing technology applied to a new context.

Remote online notarization became legal in Florida on January 1, 2020. I know that date precisely because I was building a business around it at the time. I became a remote online notary. I learned the platform thoroughly. I notarized

mortgages, reverse mortgages, home equity lines, power of attorney documents, and general notary work, appearing in living rooms and offices across multiple states, conducting identity verification sessions recorded from start to finish, credential-analyzed, journalized, and stored for a minimum of ten years under Florida law.

The person had to appear on camera. Present a government-issued identification document. The platform performed credential analysis. The notary examined the document and the person simultaneously. Dynamic knowledge-based authentication questions were asked. The session was recorded. A journal entry was created.

When the session was done, there was a record. A real one. Not a log of keystrokes and IP addresses. A recording of a human being, showing their face, presenting their identification, answering questions, swearing to the contents of what they were signing.

I understood that this process, embedded into wire transfer authorization, would change the evidentiary position of the institution and the member in a way that the existing process could not.

When a member initiates a wire transfer above a defined threshold, the process routes to a remote online notarization session before reaching queue review. The member appears before a commissioned notary. They are identified. They are recorded. They sign the authorization not with a click but with a sworn acknowledgment. The notary journals the transaction. The recording is stored.

The institution then receives not just a form submission but a notarized, recorded, identity-verified authorization event. With a bonded recovery mechanism built in. Every commissioned remote online notary carries a bond. Many carry errors and omissions insurance in addition. If fraud occurs despite that process, there is now a recording of the deception. A face on camera. A sworn statement. Avenues to accountability that the previous process did not create. And a financial recovery path through the notary's bond and insurance that did not exist before.

I believed this was worth building. I still believe it.

Here is where I have to be honest with myself.

I was right about the idea. I was not right about how I brought it forward.

I went to the wrong rooms first. I reached out to people at levels I had not yet built the trust to approach. I sent communications that were dense with detail when they should have been simple invitations to a conversation. I let my excitement about the solution outrun my understanding of the politics required to move it.

I submitted proposals through channels that were new and not fully trusted. I spent hours on spreadsheets and workflow diagrams and ROI projections that no one had asked me to produce and that, when presented without the relationship to give them credibility, read as the ambitious overreach of someone operating outside their lane.

I was an assistant branch manager. And in the architecture of a financial institution, an assistant branch manager who

builds a proposal touching payment services, fraud operations, member services, compliance, vendor relationships, and legal liability is not typically received as a systems thinker. They are typically received as someone who does not understand their role.

I understood my role. I also understood that my role did not determine the ceiling of what I could see.

That tension. Between what I saw and what I was permitted to say about what I saw. Between the idea and the channel required to advance it. Between the value I believed I was offering and the credibility the institution was willing to extend. That tension was real, and I did not always navigate it well, and I carry my portion of that honestly.

But I also know that an idea does not fail only because of the person who carries it. Sometimes it fails because the organization is not yet in enough pain to be willing to change. Sometimes the people in the rooms that matter are measured on metrics that make friction look like a problem rather than a feature. Sometimes the political cost of accepting an idea from the wrong person outweighs the operational benefit of the idea itself.

I watched ideas die for all of those reasons. Including my own.

I am sharing this because I have looked into the faces of the people it costs.

I have watched members sit across from me and learn, in real time, that the money they counted on is gone. That the process they trusted did not protect them the way they believed it would. That the regulation governing what the institution owes them is not the same as what their gut told them they were owed.

Institutions are not inclined to pay out where they cannot find liability on their side. That is not cynicism. That is how the regulatory structure is written. Wire fraud recovery operates under a different framework from debit card fraud. Members are often told, accurately and devastatingly, that the money is gone.

I know what that looks like from the front line. I know what it costs the member and what it costs the person sitting across from them trying to help.

So I am not going to tell you the framework is available if you ask. I am sharing it. Because the game is usually to be sold, not told. And I have watched enough people lose enough money to be done playing that game.

The wire fraud gap I identified still exists. The tool that addresses it still exists. The institutions still losing money to it still exist.

I am no longer inside the institution. I no longer have to navigate the politics of advancing an idea through a hierarchy that was not built to receive it from where I was standing.

So I am saying it here instead.

Not as a complaint. Not as a product pitch. Not as a resume item dressed up as thought leadership. As a pattern worth naming. Because the experience of watching a good idea die in the wrong room is not unique to me. Every organization has people in it who see something clearly and cannot get the institution to look where they are pointing. The cost of that gap is not always visible on a balance sheet. But it is real. And it accumulates.

If you work in fraud risk, compliance, or financial operations and you have watched this happen from either side of the table, I would like to hear about it.

And the framework is attached. Freely given.

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This piece reflects the author's own observations, analysis, and professional experience. No proprietary systems, confidential institutional data, or protected member information is disclosed. The framework described draws entirely on publicly available regulatory information and the author's independent analysis.